

INSIGHT LAB

MINDFULNESS WORKSHOPS

mindfulness for educators



Mindfulness for Educators

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Contents

Contents	2
Workshop Overview	3
Objectives	3
Agenda	3
Introduction to Mindfulness	3
Science of Mindfulness	3
Practicing Mindfulness	4
Mindfulness Pedagogy in the Classroom	4
Practical Tips for Bringing Mindfulness into the Classroom	4
Questions, Discussion, and Collective Brainstorming	5
Workshop Details	5
Expected Outcomes	5
Target Audience	5
Follow-Up	6
Conclusion	6
Bio	6

Workshop Overview

In many ways, this vocation we've chosen is a practice of mindfulness. The purpose of this workshop is to find ways to build on that practice. We'll explore the foundations of mindfulness, experiment with simple practices, and learn practical strategies to bring more mindfulness into our teaching. Where a lot of mindfulness trainings focus mainly on reducing stress and anxiety, we will broaden our focus to include the ways it can infuse our lives and our work with more curiosity, joy and compassion.

Objectives

1. **Understand** the basics of mindfulness, including its history, scientific foundation, and philosophical roots, to gain insights into its relevance in education, as well as our lives more broadly.
2. **Experience** mindfulness through simple and accessible meditations, as well as mindful communication exercises
3. **Learn** the pedagogy of mindfulness and how it can be incorporated into teaching any subject
4. **Apply** practical strategies for incorporating mindfulness into everyday classroom interactions and curriculum.

Agenda

Introduction to Mindfulness

- **History and Philosophy:** We will start with a brief overview of the roots of mindfulness, exploring its origins in various contemplative traditions and how it has evolved into a secular practice accessible to all.

Science of Mindfulness

- We'll delve into recent research showing how mindfulness positively impacts mental clarity, emotional regulation, resilience, and compassion.
- **Relevance to Education:** We'll will discuss how mindfulness can support our work as educators.

Practicing Mindfulness

- **Guided Practices:** Participants will engage in three mindfulness exercises:
 - *Anchoring Attention* – An introductory practice that provides a taste of what it's like to anchor our attention to a sensation
 - *Focused Attention and Open Monitoring* – Exploring the two primary modes of attention
 - *Mindful Communication* – An interactive exercise focused on listening deeply and responding mindfully, an essential skill in classroom dynamics and student engagement.

Mindfulness Pedagogy in the Classroom

- **Four Characteristics of a Mindfulness Teacher:** We'll discuss what makes an effective mindfulness teacher and how those characteristics can be incorporated into our own teaching.
- **"The Pedagogy is the Practice":** One of the hallmarks of good mindfulness education is that teaching is a mindfulness practice itself. We'll explore the ways this is true in teaching anything.

Practical Tips for Bringing Mindfulness into the Classroom

- **Mindfulness as an Orientation:** Mindfulness is not just not a set of practices. We'll look at how this orientation can be brought into the classroom (without necessarily introducing specific practices).
- **Building Simple Habits:** How to incorporate small moments of mindfulness into daily routines, such as mindful breathing before assessments, or mindful walking between classes.
- **Modeling Mindfulness:** The importance of teachers embodying mindfulness as a role model for students, even in challenging situations.
- **Mindfulness Tools for Students:** Practical ways to introduce age-appropriate mindfulness practices to students, like mindful listening or gratitude practices, to support their focus, emotional regulation, and resilience.
- **Using Mindfulness Scales:** We'll brainstorm ways to adapt some of the commonly used mindfulness scales/questionnaires for use with our students.

Questions, Discussion, and Collective Brainstorming

- This workshop is designed to be interactive. After each practice, we'll have plenty of time for discussion, questions.
- **Group Brainstorming:** We will collaborate on ideas to incorporate mindfulness in our teaching.

Workshop Details

- **Duration:** 1.5 hours - 2.5 hours, depending on our goals. This can be adapted to suit the group's needs.
- **Format:** In-person or virtual, structured as an interactive seminar.
- **Materials:** Handouts summarizing each practice, recommended readings, and a list of mindfulness tools and resources.

Expected Outcomes

By the end of this workshop, educators will have:

- A foundational understanding of mindfulness and its applications within the teaching profession.
- Practical experience with mindfulness exercises they can use for personal and professional growth.
- Strategies to integrate mindfulness practices that enhance classroom dynamics and support student well-being.
- New ideas for fostering a compassionate, mindful learning environment that promotes resilience and joy in teaching and learning.

Target Audience

This workshop is ideal for educators of all grade levels who wish to bring a mindful presence into their classrooms, reduce stress, and connect more deeply with their students and their work.

Follow-Up

For those interested, I will send out weekly emails for four weeks including guided meditations and other mindfulness practices, along with brief remarks on practice and new research on mindfulness.

Conclusion

This professional development workshop offers teachers practical tools and insights that can transform both their professional and personal lives.

Through the practice and pedagogy of mindfulness, educators can cultivate a supportive learning environment that nurtures curiosity, resilience, and emotional well-being for both students and teachers alike. Most importantly, it can help us connect more deeply with our work, our students, and ourselves, bringing greater fulfillment and joy into the vocation to which we've been called.

Bio

I hold a Doctorate of Education from Drexel University, where I've been teaching mathematics since 2010. More recently, I've been teaching courses and running workshops for students and faculty on mindfulness and other contemplative practices. My research interests include undergraduate math education, social-emotional learning in STEM education, and mindfulness pedagogy.

As a lifelong meditator, studying with teachers from various traditions over the years, I've always thought of teaching as just another mindfulness practice, and I'm excited to share that with you.